

ART & CULTURE



INDIAN ARCHITECTURE

MODULE - 25

**NCERT NOTES ON
MEDIEVAL ARCHITECTURE**

NCERT NOTES

MEDIEVAL ARCHITECTURE

DECORATIVE FORMS

ART & CULTURE



INDIAN ARCHITECTURE

MODULE - 21

ARCHITECTURE IN MEDIEVAL INDIA

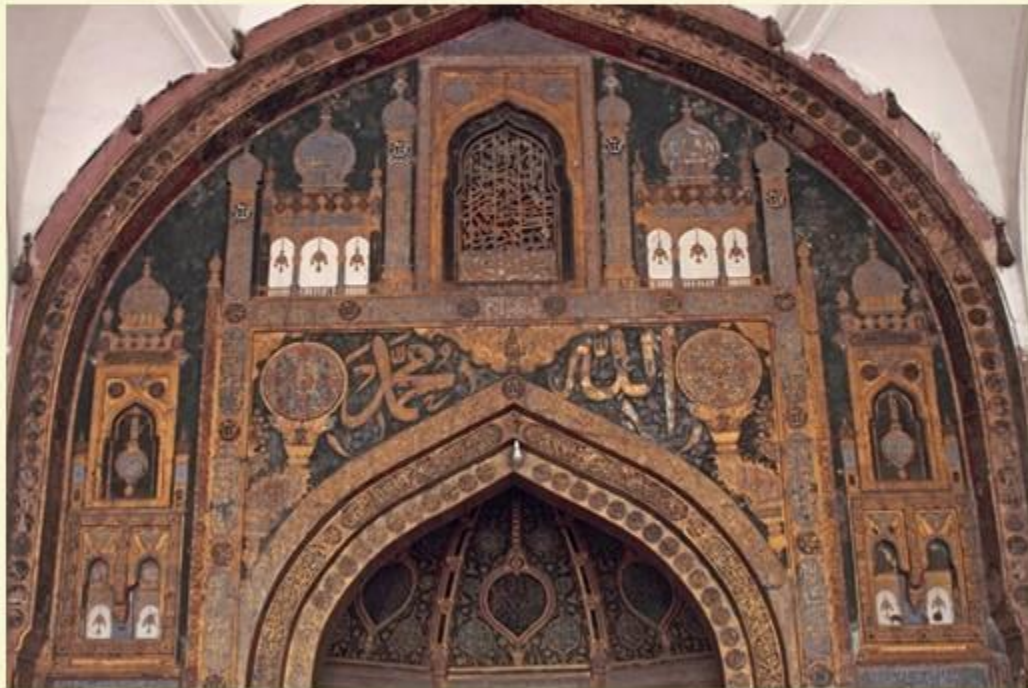
Watch Module 21 along with this module to comprehensively understand the nuances of Islamic architecture

NCERT NOTES

MEDIEVAL ARCHITECTURE

1

DECORATIVE FORMS



STUCCO WORK IN AKBAR'S TOMB

1

These forms include designing on plasters through incisions or stucco.

2

The designs were either left plain or covered with colours.

3

Motifs were also painted on or carved in stones.

4

These motifs include varieties of flowers, both from sub-continent and places outside, particularly Iran.

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MEDIEVAL ARCHITECTURE

1

DECORATIVE FORMS



CENTRAL ARCH WITH LOTUS BUD FRINGE AT QILA-I-KUHNA MASJID

- 5 The **lotus bud fringe** was used to great advantage in the inner curves of the arches.
- 6 The walls were also **decorated with Cypress, Chinar, and other trees** as also with **flower vases**.
- 7 Many complex designs of flower motifs decorating the ceiling were also to be found on textiles and carpets.
- 8 In the **14th, 15th and 16th centuries**, **tiles were also used** to surface the walls and the domes.

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MEDIEVAL ARCHITECTURE

1

DECORATIVE FORMS

- 9 Popular colours were blue, turquoise, green and yellow.



TESSELLATION IN DODO PANELS

- 10 Subsequently the techniques of tessellation (mosaic designs) and pietra dura (cut and fit technique) were made use of for surface decoration, particularly in the dodo panels of the walls.

- 11 At times, Lapis Lazuli (a kind of blue stone) was used on the interior walls or on canopies.

- 12 Arabesque (surface decorations based on rhythmic linear patterns of scrolling and interlacing foliage, tendrils), calligraphy, Jalis (perforated stone or latticed screen), etc. were other decorative works.

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MEDIEVAL ARCHITECTURE

2

CONSTRUCTION MATERIALS

1 The walls in all buildings were extremely thick and were largely constructed of rubble masonry, which were easily available.

2 These walls were then cased over with chunam or limestone plaster or dressed stone.

3 An amazing ranges of stones were utilized for construction such as quartzite, sandstone, buffs, marbles, etc.

4 Polychrome tiles were used to great advantage to finish the walls.

5 From the 17th century onwards, bricks were also used for construction and in this phase there was more reliance on local materials.

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MEDIEVAL ARCHITECTURE

3

FORTS



CHITTORGARH FORT

- 1 Building monumental forts with embattlement was a regular feature in medieval times, often symbolizing the seat of power of a king.
- 2 When such a fort was captured by an attacking army, the vanquished ruler either lost his complete power or his sovereignty.
- 3 This was because he had to accept the suzerainty of the victorious king.
- 4 Commanding heights were utilized to great advantage to construct forts.

NCERT NOTES

MEDIEVAL ARCHITECTURE

3

FORTS



GOLCONDA FORT

5

Another feature was **concentric circles of outer walls** as in Golconda that the enemy had to breach these at all stages before getting in.

6

Some of the famous forts are the **Fort of Chittor (Rajasthan)**, **Gwalior (MP)**, **Daulatabad-earlier Devgiri (Maharashtra)**, and **Golconda (Hyderabad)**.

7

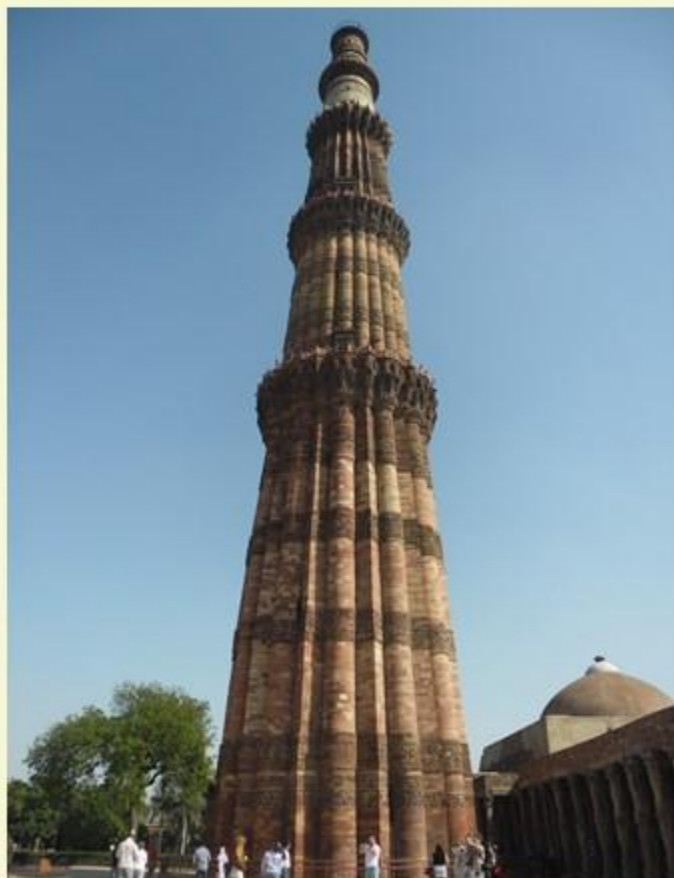
The **Chittorgarh fort** is the **largest fort in Asia** and was occupied for the longest length of time as the seat of power.

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MEDIEVAL ARCHITECTURE

4

MINARS



1 Another form of **sthamba** or tower was the **minar**, a common feature in the sub-continent.

2 The most striking minars of medieval times are the **Qutub Minar in Delhi** and **Chand Minar at Daulatabad**.

3 The everyday use of the minar was for the **azaan** or call to prayer.

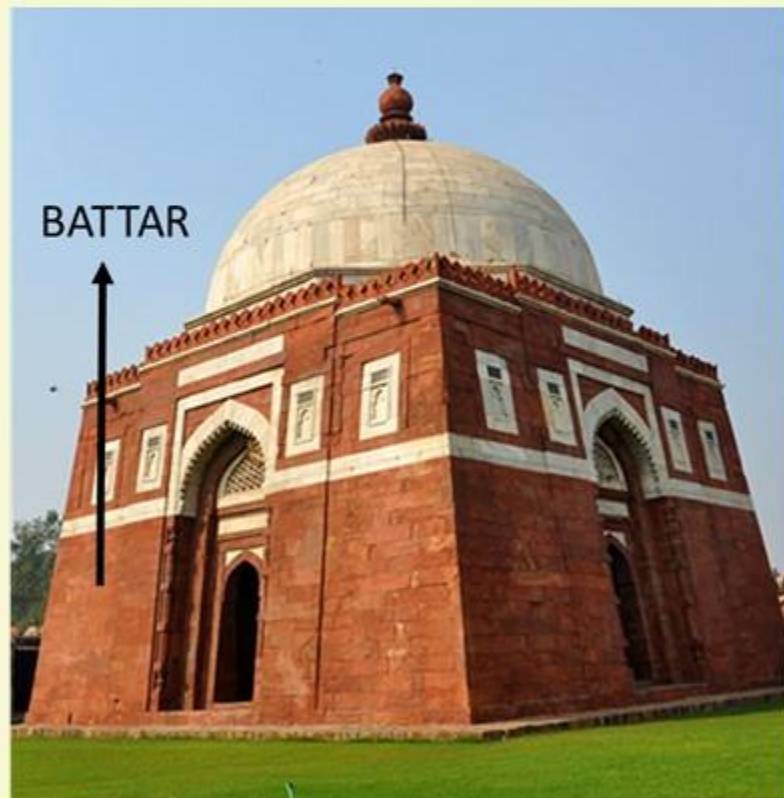
4 Its phenomenal height, however, symbolized the **might and power** of the ruler.

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5

TOMBS



**TOMB OF
GHIYASUDDIN TUGHLAQ**

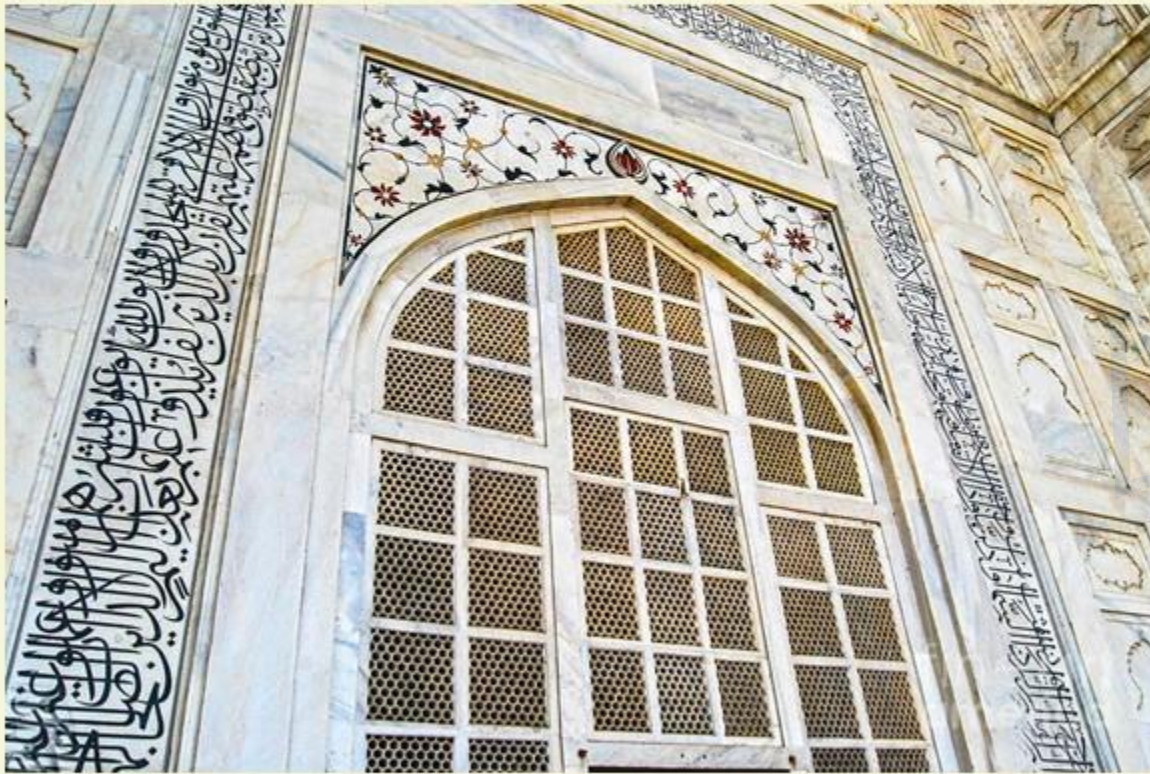
- 1 Monumental structures over graves of rulers and royalty was a popular feature of medieval India.
- 2 Some well known examples of such tombs are those of Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq, Humayun, Adur Rahim Khan-i-Khanan, Akbar, and Itmaduddaula.
- 3 The idea behind raising the tomb was eternal paradise as a reward for the true believer of religion.

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MEDIEVAL ARCHITECTURE

5

TOMBS



QURANIC VERSES ON TAJ MAHAL

4 Beginning with the introduction of Quranic verses on the walls, the tomb was subsequently placed with paradisiacal elements such as garden or near a water body or both, as in the case of Taj Mahal.

5 They were not only intended to signify peace and happiness in the next world, but also to showcase the majesty, grandeur and might of the person buried there.

E.g.: Taj Mahal

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MEDIEVAL ARCHITECTURE

5

TOMBS

- 1 What are the significant features of Indo-Islamic architecture inculcated in the Taj Mahal?

HINTS: Add points from both the forthcoming points pertaining to Taj Mahal and from Module 21 of Features of Islamic Architecture

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MEDIEVAL ARCHITECTURE

5

TOMBS

TAJ MAHAL



RED SANDSTONE GATEWAY OF TAJ

- 1 Taj Mahal was built in Agra by **Shah Jahan** as a **mausoleum** (a kind of large tomb) for his deceased wife **Mumtaz Mahal**.
- 2 It was commissioned in the year of 1632 and is a **UNESCO World Heritage Site**.
- 3 Taj Mahal was the **apogee** of the **evolutionary architectural process** in Medieval India.
- 4 The Taj complex is entered through a **monumental red sandstone gateway**, the opening arch of which beautifully frames the mausoleum.

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MEDIEVAL ARCHITECTURE

5

TOMBS

TAJ MAHAL



TAJ MAHAL ON RIVER YAMUNA

- 5 The tomb is laid out in a **Chahar Bagh** (garden), crisscrossed with paths and **water courses**, interspersed with pools and fountains.
- 6 The structure is placed on the northern extremity of the bagh to take advantage of the river bank (Yamuna).
- 7 The straight path through the bagh reaches the **plinth** of the tomb.

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5

TOMBS

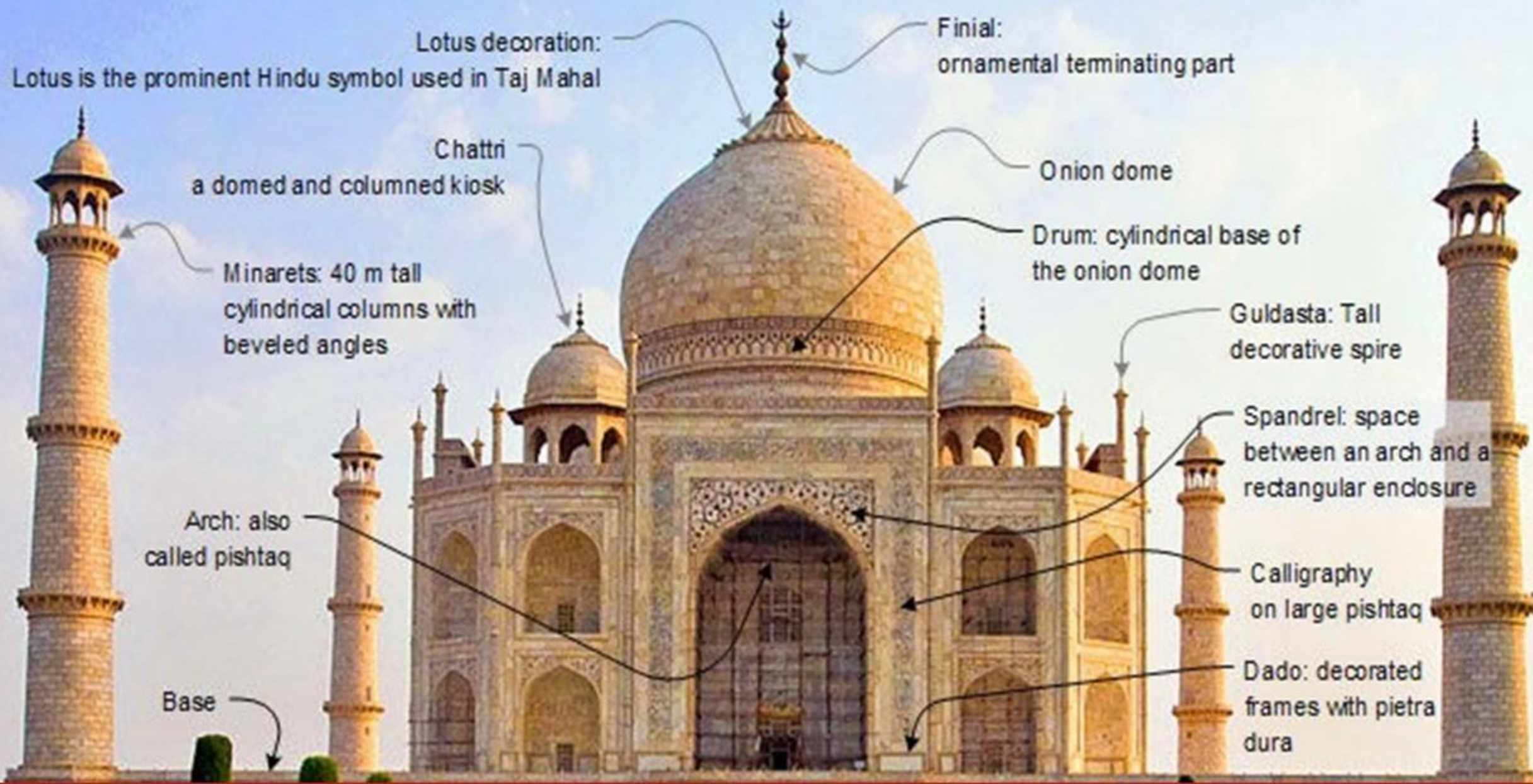
TAJ MAHAL



**MAKRANA MARBLES FROM
RAJASTHAN**

- 8** At the corners of the terrace stand **four tall minarets, one hundred and thirty two feet high.**
- 9** The main body of the building is topped with a **drum and a dome and four chattris forming a beautiful skyline.**
- 10** Towards the west of the white marble faced tomb lies a **red sandstone mosque and a similar construction in the east to maintain balance.**
- 11** The marbles for the building was quarried from the **Makrana Mines, Rajasthan.**

TAJ MAHAL



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5

TOMBS

TAJ MAHAL



The cenotaphs honoring Mumtaz Mahal and Shah Jahan are enclosed in an eight-sided chamber ornamented with pietra dura

12 The inner arrangement of the mausoleum consists of a crypt below and a vaulted, octagonal tomb chamber, with a room at each angle, all connected by corridors.

13 Light to every part of the building is obtained by means of carved and perforated Jalis, set in the arched recesses of the interior.

14 Four types of embellishments have been used with great effect for the interior and exterior surfaces of the Taj Mahal.

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MEDIEVAL ARCHITECTURE

5

TOMBS

TAJ MAHAL



Pietra-dura Technique

15 These are stone carvings in high and low relief on the walls, the delicate carving of marble into jalis and graceful volutes (spiral ornament on the pillars), and the creation of arabesque with pietra dura on walls and tombstones and geometric designs with tessellation.

16 The art of calligraphy is used with the inlay of jasper in white marble to unite Quranic verses.

17 Calligraphy provides a decorative element on the walls and a continuous connection with the almighty.

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MEDIEVAL ARCHITECTURE

6

SARAIS



SARAIS

- 1 Sarais were largely built on a simple square or a rectangular plan and were meant to provide temporary accommodation for Indian and foreign travelers, pilgrims, merchants, traders, etc.
- 2 They were public domains which thronged with people of varied cultural backgrounds.
- 3 This led to cross cultural interaction, influence and syncretic tendencies in the cultural mores of the times and at the level of people.

NCERT NOTES

MEDIEVAL ARCHITECTURE

7 STRUCTURES FOR COMMON PEOPLE



KHANQAHS

- 1 One of the architectural features of medieval India was **also a coming together of styles, techniques, and decorations in public and private spaces for non-royal sections of the society.**
- 2 These include buildings for domestic usage, temples, mosques, Khanqahs and dargahs, commemorative gateways, pavilions in the buildings and gardens, bazaars, etc.

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MEDIEVAL ARCHITECTURE

7 STRUCTURES FOR COMMON PEOPLE

JAMA MASJID



JAMA MASJID IN AGRA

- 1 Large mosques spanning huge spaces also dotted the landscapes of the Indian sub-continent in medieval times.
- 2 **Congregational prayers** were held here every Friday afternoon, which required the presence of minimum of forty Muslim male adults.
- 3 At the time of prayers, a **khutba** was read out in the name of the ruler and his laws for the realm were also read out.
- 4 In medieval times, a city had one Jama Masjid which, along with its immediate surroundings, became the focus of the lives of the people, both Muslim and Non-Muslim.

NCERT NOTES

MEDIEVAL ARCHITECTURE

7 STRUCTURES FOR COMMON PEOPLE

JAMA MASJID



MIHRAB

5 This happened because a lot of commercial and cultural exchanges were concentrated here besides religious and indirect political activity.

6 Generally, such a mosque was large with an open courtyard, surrounded on three sides by cloisters and the Qibla Liwan in the west.

7 It was here that the mihrab and mimbar for the Imam were located.

8 People faced the mihrab while offering prayers as it indicated the direction of the Kaaba in Mecca.

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